

Advanced Placement United States History

Unit 2 Long Essay Question (LEQ)

The long essay question requires students to do the following:

Respond to the prompt with a historically defensible thesis or claim that establishes a line of reasoning.

Describe a broader historical context relevant to the prompt.

Support an argument in response to the prompt using at least two pieces of specific and relevant evidence.

Demonstrate a complex understanding of a historical development related to the prompt through sophisticated argumentation and/or effective use of evidence.

Introductory statement:

After the French and Indian War, Great Britain tightened its control over its North American colonies, and colonists developed new and increasingly organized ways to resist British authority.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which British imperial policies influenced the development of colonial resistance in British North America during the period from 1754 to 1776.

Students might consider the French and Indian War, the Proclamation of 1763, the Stamp Act, the Townshend Acts, the Committees of Correspondence, the Coercive Acts, or the First Continental Congress.

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Introductory statement:

In the early 1700s Great Britain governed its North American colonies loosely, but by the end of the eighteenth century the colonies had won their independence.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which the relationship between Great Britain and its North American colonies changed during the period from 1720 to 1783.

Students might consider salutary neglect, the French and Indian War, the Albany Plan of Union, the Stamp Act and the Declaratory Act, the Second Continental Congress, the Declaration of Independence, or the Treaty of Paris (1783).

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Introductory statement:

Colonists who first protested British taxes as loyal subjects increasingly justified their resistance with ideas about representation and natural rights.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which ideas about rights and representation influenced the movement toward independence in British North America during the period from 1763 to 1776.

Students might consider virtual and actual representation, the Real Whigs, John Locke, the Stamp Act Congress, the Declaration of Rights and Grievances, Common Sense, or the Declaration of Independence.

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Introductory statement:

The Continental Army faced the most powerful military in the world, yet the colonists won their independence with help from abroad.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which foreign assistance influenced the outcome of the American Revolution during the period from 1775 to 1783.

Students might consider the Second Continental Congress, George Washington's strategy, the Battle of Saratoga, the Franco-American Alliance, the war in the South, the Battle of Yorktown, or the Treaty of Paris (1783).

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Introductory statement:

During the eighteenth century, immigration and religious revival changed the makeup and the beliefs of colonial society in British North America.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which immigration and religious revival changed colonial society in British North America during the period from 1720 to 1776.

Students might consider natural increase, enslaved Africans, German and Scots-Irish immigration, Jonathan Edwards, George Whitefield, New Lights and Old Lights, or religious toleration.

Key · Practice prompt 1

Evaluate the extent to which British imperial policies influenced the development of colonial resistance in British North America during the period from 1754 to 1776.

What to explain

How each British policy after the French and Indian War made colonial resistance bigger and more organized.

Context to say

1. For decades Britain governed its colonies through salutary neglect: trade laws such as the Molasses Act (1733) went unenforced, and colonial assemblies controlled their own taxes.
2. Colonial population grew rapidly through natural increase, and German and Scots-Irish settlers pushed toward the backcountry and the Ohio Valley, land France also claimed.
3. The First Great Awakening of the 1730s and 1740s split congregations and taught ordinary colonists to question established authority.
4. Still, the colonies stayed divided: in 1754 every assembly rejected the Albany Plan of Union.
5. Then say the thesis below.

Thesis to say

British imperial policies influenced the development of colonial resistance to a large extent, because the debt from the French and Indian War led Parliament to tax the colonies for revenue and then punish Massachusetts, and each new policy produced a larger and more organized colonial response; however, colonial beliefs about actual representation explain why those policies were seen as tyranny.

Body 1 · The war ends salutary neglect (1754 to 1764)

- French and Indian War (1754 to 1763): Britain wins but is deep in debt. Link: the debt is why Parliament now wants revenue from the colonies.
- Proclamation of 1763 after Pontiac's Rebellion: no settlement west of the Appalachians. Link: British policy now limits colonists' land, not only their trade.
- Sugar Act and Currency Act (1764): revenue duty enforced, no colonial paper money. Link: enforcement replaces neglect, and protest begins.

Say: Because the French and Indian War left Britain deep in debt, Parliament ended salutary neglect and began taxing and limiting the colonies, which is what first turned colonists against British policy.

Body 2 · Taxes create organized resistance (1765 to 1770)

- Stamp Act (1765): Sons of Liberty, boycotts, and the Stamp Act Congress of 9 colonies; repealed in 1766, but the Declaratory Act keeps Parliament's claim. Link: a direct tax produces the first joint colonial action.
- Townshend Acts (1767): duties pay royal officials; John Dickinson's letters, the Daughters of Liberty and new boycotts; troops sent to Boston, then the Boston Massacre (1770). Link: each tax widens who resists and how.

Say: Each new tax produced a larger and more united response, from riots to boycotts to a congress of nine colonies, which shows British policy was building the resistance it meant to stop.

Body 3 · Punishment unites the colonies (1772 to 1776)

- Committees of Correspondence (1772) and the Tea Act and Boston Tea Party (1773). Link: resistance becomes an intercolonial network.
- Coercive Acts (1774) close Boston's port and gut the Massachusetts charter; the First Continental Congress answers with the Declaration of Rights and Grievances and a boycott. Link: the punishment meant to isolate Boston unites the colonies.
- Lexington and Concord (1775), then Common Sense and the Declaration of Independence (1776). Link: resistance ends in independence.

Say: By punishing Massachusetts with the Coercive Acts, Britain united the colonies instead of isolating Boston, and that unity led to the Continental Congress and, finally, independence.

Complexity

- However, British policies alone do not explain the resistance: colonists believed only their own elected assemblies could tax them, so the same taxes Britain saw as fair looked like tyranny.
- Even so, resistance had limits: as late as 1775 the Olive Branch Petition asked the king for reconciliation, and about one in five colonists stayed Loyalist.

Key · Practice prompt 2

Evaluate the extent to which the relationship between Great Britain and its North American colonies changed during the period from 1720 to 1783.

What to explain

How the relationship went from loose rule to direct control to independence, and what stayed the same.

Context to say

1. After the Glorious Revolution (1688), England restored colonial assemblies and ended the Dominion of New England.
2. Under mercantilism the Navigation Acts were meant to make the colonies serve England's economy.
3. Britain and France fought King William's War and Queen Anne's War (1702 to 1713) over North America, settling nothing.
4. By 1720 the colonies were loyal British subjects who largely ran their own affairs.
5. Then say the thesis below.

Thesis to say

The relationship between Great Britain and its colonies changed to a great extent, from loose rule under salutary neglect to open war and independence, because the French and Indian War led Britain to tax and control the colonies directly; however, the colonists' claim to govern themselves through their own elected assemblies stayed the same, and that continuity is what turned new policies into a break.

Body 1 · Loose ties (1720 to 1754)

- Salutary neglect: trade laws barely enforced; the Molasses Act (1733) went unenforced. Link: colonists grew used to self-government.
- Albany Plan of Union (1754) rejected by every assembly. Link: the colonies were still separate and loyal, not united against Britain.

Say: Before 1754 the relationship was loose: Britain barely enforced its trade laws, so colonists grew used to governing themselves while staying loyal and divided.

Body 2 · Tightening control (1754 to 1774)

- French and Indian War (1754 to 1763) and the Treaty of Paris (1763): France leaves, Britain is in debt. Link: the turning point that ends neglect.
- Stamp Act (1765) and the Declaratory Act (1766): Parliament claims power "in all cases whatsoever." Link: the relationship becomes a fight over who may tax the colonies.
- Coercive Acts (1774): Massachusetts punished. Link: control by force replaces negotiation.

Say: After the French and Indian War, Britain tried to tax and control the colonies directly, which turned a loose relationship into a struggle over who had the power to govern them.

Body 3 · The break (1775 to 1783)

- Second Continental Congress (1775): Washington named commander; the Olive Branch Petition is refused. Link: the colonies act as a government of their own.
- Declaration of Independence (1776) and the Treaty of Paris (1783): independence, recognized by Britain. Link: the relationship ends in separation.

Say: When fighting began and the king refused the Olive Branch Petition, the colonists created their own government and declared independence, and the Treaty of Paris (1783) made the break official.

Complexity

- However, one thing stayed the same from 1720 to 1783: colonists insisted on governing themselves through their own elected assemblies, and that continuity is what turned British control into a break.
- Independence also changed less for some people than others: Loyalists lost their property, and Britain's Native allies were left out of the peace.

Key · Practice prompt 3

Evaluate the extent to which ideas about rights and representation influenced the movement toward independence in British North America during the period from 1763 to 1776.

What to explain

How ideas about representation and natural rights turned protests over taxes into a case for independence.

Context to say

1. Britain won the French and Indian War in 1763 but was left deeply in debt.
2. For decades colonial assemblies had controlled their own taxes under salutary neglect.
3. The First Great Awakening had already taught colonists to question established authority.
4. Pontiac's Rebellion and the Proclamation of 1763 showed that London now meant to manage the colonies directly.
5. Then say the thesis below.

Thesis to say

Ideas about rights and representation influenced the movement toward independence to a large extent, because the colonists' belief in actual representation turned British taxes into a constitutional crisis and John Locke's natural rights justified the final break; however, ideas alone did not cause independence, since British policies and the fighting that began in 1775 forced the decision.

Body 1 · Representation (1765 to 1774)

- Virtual representation (Britain) vs. actual representation (colonists): only elected assemblies could tax. Link: this is why the Stamp Act (1765) was rejected on principle.
- Stamp Act Congress (1765) and the First Continental Congress's Declaration of Rights and Grievances (1774): trade regulation accepted, revenue taxes rejected. Link: the protest rested on an idea, not just the cost.
Say: Because colonists believed only their own elected representatives could tax them, they treated the Stamp Act as a violation of their rights rather than just a cost, which turned protest into a matter of principle.

Body 2 · Fear of power

- Real Whigs: English writers who warned that concentrated power threatens liberty. Link: each act looked like part of a plot.
- Townshend Acts (1767) paid royal officials, threatening the assemblies' power of the purse; the Coercive Acts (1774) gutted the Massachusetts charter. Link: colonists read both as proof of the plot.
Say: Because the Real Whigs had taught colonists to fear concentrated power, each new act looked like part of a plan to take away their liberty, which made compromise harder.

Body 3 · Natural rights and independence (1776)

- Common Sense (1776): Thomas Paine's plain argument for independence. Link: shifts opinion from rights as Englishmen to a break.
- Declaration of Independence (1776): Locke's natural rights, consent of the governed, the right to alter or abolish, grievances against the king. Link: the ideas become the justification for independence.
Say: Common Sense and the Declaration of Independence moved the argument from rights as Englishmen to natural rights, which gave colonists a reason to break with the king entirely.

Complexity

- The ideas themselves changed: in 1775 Congress still asked for colonists' rights as Englishmen, but by 1776 it claimed natural rights and independence.
- However, ideas alone did not cause independence: the Coercive Acts, the fighting at Lexington and Concord, and the king's refusal of the Olive Branch Petition forced the decision.
- These ideas also had limits, since they did not free enslaved people; Dunmore's Proclamation offered freedom from the British side instead.

Key · Practice prompt 4

Evaluate the extent to which foreign assistance influenced the outcome of the American Revolution during the period from 1775 to 1783.

What to explain

How French help after Saratoga turned survival into victory, and how much the Americans did on their own.

Context to say

1. The French and Indian War gave colonists military experience, including a young George Washington at Fort Mifflin (1754).
2. Britain's war debt led to taxes that colonists resisted from 1765 on.
3. The Coercive Acts (1774) led to the First Continental Congress.
4. Fighting began at Lexington and Concord in 1775, against the strongest navy and a professional army.
5. Then say the thesis below.

Thesis to say

Foreign assistance influenced the outcome of the American Revolution to a large extent, because after Saratoga the French alliance supplied troops, money and a navy that made the decisive victory at Yorktown possible; however, the Americans first had to survive on their own, through Washington's strategy of avoiding decisive losses and a Second Continental Congress that kept the war going.

Body 1 · Surviving alone (1775 to 1777)

- Second Continental Congress (1775): names Washington commander and prints paper money. Link: a government kept the war alive.
- Washington's strategy: avoid decisive losses and keep the army together; home ground meant British supplies crossed an ocean. Link: survival made foreign help possible.

Say: Because the Second Continental Congress kept a government and an army going, and Washington avoided decisive losses, the Americans survived long enough for foreign help to matter.

Body 2 · Saratoga brings France (1777 to 1778)

- Saratoga (1777): a whole British army surrenders. Link: proves the Americans can win.
- Franco-American Alliance (1778): troops, advisors, gunpowder and a navy that could challenge Britain's. Link: Britain now fights a world power.

Say: The victory at Saratoga proved the Americans could win, which convinced France to ally with them and turned a colonial rebellion into a war Britain fought against a world power.

Body 3 · The South and Yorktown (1778 to 1783)

- After Saratoga Britain moves the war South, expecting Loyalist support, but fails to hold the countryside. Link: Britain could win battles without winning control.
- Yorktown (1781): the French navy and an allied army trap a British army; Britain stops offensive operations. The Treaty of Paris (1783) recognizes independence. Link: foreign help produced the decisive end.

Say: French troops and the French navy made Yorktown possible, and that surrender led Britain to stop offensive operations and negotiate the Treaty of Paris (1783).

Complexity

- The causes depended on each other: American survival led to Saratoga, Saratoga led to the French alliance, and the alliance led to Yorktown.
- Britain also lost the war in its own ways: its supplies crossed an ocean, it failed to control the southern countryside, and looting by its troops pushed neutral colonists toward the Patriots.

Key · Practice prompt 5

Evaluate the extent to which immigration and religious revival changed colonial society in British North America during the period from 1720 to 1776.

What to explain

How immigrants, enslaved Africans and the Great Awakening made colonial society more diverse and more willing to question authority.

Context to say

1. By 1700 the colonies were mostly English settlements along the coast.
2. The Chesapeake and South Carolina had become slave societies, while New England remained a society with slaves.
3. Established churches, Puritan in New England and Anglican in the South, shaped colonial life.
4. After the Glorious Revolution the colonists saw themselves as loyal Protestant British subjects.
5. Then say the thesis below.

Thesis to say

Immigration and religious revival changed colonial society to a large extent, because German and Scots-Irish immigrants and enslaved Africans made the colonies far more diverse and the First Great Awakening split the established churches and encouraged colonists to question authority; however, colonists remained loyal British subjects into the 1760s, and slavery and the power of local elites continued.

Body 1 · Growth and forced migration

- Natural increase: most of the population growth came from births, not immigration. Link: a fast-growing population pushed west for land.
- Enslaved Africans were the largest group of newcomers, involuntary migrants. Link: slavery grew alongside the free population.

Say: Because most growth came from natural increase, the colonial population grew fast and pushed west for land, while slavery grew alongside the free population.

Body 2 · A less English society

- German and Scots-Irish immigrants, most after 1730, many to Pennsylvania and the backcountry. Link: the colonies became more diverse and less English.
- Backcountry settlement pressed on western land. Link: this connects to the land conflicts behind the Proclamation of 1763.

Say: German and Scots-Irish immigrants made the colonies less English and more diverse, and their settlement in the backcountry pressed on western land.

Body 3 · The First Great Awakening (1730s to 1740s)

- Jonathan Edwards ("Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God") and George Whitefield, an itinerant preacher who drew huge crowds. Link: emotional, personal religion reached ordinary colonists.
- New Lights vs. Old Lights: congregations split, denominations multiplied, toleration grew. Link: authority could be challenged from below.

Say: The First Great Awakening split congregations and multiplied denominations, which taught ordinary colonists that they could challenge established authority.

Complexity

- However, much stayed the same: colonists were still loyal British subjects into the 1760s, and slavery expanded rather than weakened.
- This connects to the next period: the habit of questioning authority that the revival encouraged helps explain why colonists resisted British policies after 1763.